

SCORE BOARD

CATEGORY	Office desktops		
Distribution name	SuSE Office Desktop	Red Hat 9.0	Mandrake 9.1
Ease of use	22.5	18	21
File system	2	2	2
Similarity to Windows	0	0	0
Suitability to office use	20	20	20
Printing subsystem	4	4	4
System administration	2	2	2
Internet readiness	1.2	1	1.2
Graphical configuration	20	18.75	20
Features	4	3	3
<i>Special features</i>	3	2	2
<i>Glaring deficiencies</i>	0.4	0.4	0.4
Resource utilisation	2.4	1.2	1.8
Desktop hardware compatibility	9.05	9.05	8.57
Windows emulation tools	4	3	0
Economy	3	5	3
Overall score	90.55	84.39	83.97

CATEGORY	Hardware compatibility		
Distribution name	SuSE Linux Office Desktop	Red Hat 9.0	Mandrake 9.1 Standard Edition
Graphics card			
nVidia GeForce MX 440 with AGP8x	✓	✓	✓
nVidia GeForce2 MX 400	✓	✓	✓
nVidia GeForce2 MX 200	✓	✓	✓
nVidia Riva TNT2	✓	✓	✓
SiS 6326	✓	✓	✓
Ethernet card			
Broadcom NetXtreme Gigabit ethernet card	✓	✓	✓
Intel Pro 100 VE	✓	✓	✓
Dlink DFE-538TX 10/100	✓	✓	✓
Intel EtherExpress PRO 100	✓	✓	✓
Sound card			
Onboard CMI 8378	✓	✓	✓
Onboard 5.1 support	✓	✓	✓
Onboard Realtek AC'97	✓	✓	✓
Aureal2	✓	✓	✗
Yamaha DS-XG	✓	✓	✓
Optical drives			
Samsung SW-240B CD-RW	✓	✓	✓
Samsung SD-616Q DVD-ROM	✓	✓	✓
Samsung SD-612 DVD-ROM	✓	✓	✓
Samsung SM-348B Combo Drive	✓	✓	✓
Modem			
Best data 56 Kbps data fax modem	✗	✗	✗
Overall score	0.90	0.90	0.86

more so in the area of checking and automatically installing dependencies before installing packages. These functionalities are currently provided only by the Debian-based apt-get, the ports-system on BSD-style operating systems, and the portage system on Gentoo Linux.

Red Hat has OpenOffice.org, which provides compatibility with existing Microsoft Office files. It is a very mature Linux distribution but does not adapt well in the office environment; rather the office user has to adapt to Red Hat, and that will take a lot of time.

Windows emulators

The purpose of Windows emulators is to provide an environment in which Windows-based programs can be executed on a Linux platform. All you need to do is load the emulator in Linux, which allows you to run your Windows application. Here, we look at the four commonly used emulators; Wine, CodeWeavers CrossOver Office, NeTraverse Win4Lin 4.0, and VMware.

Wine

Wine is an open source implementation that can be downloaded for free from www.winehq.com. It runs the Win 32 and Win 16 API on Linux. Hence, you can execute almost any of your Win 32, Win 16 or DOS applications. It provides X11-based graphical support, DirectX support as well as text based console. Support for sound devices, input devices, printing devices, scanners and CD writers, are also included. Even bug detection occurs similar to that on a Windows PC.

Code Weavers CrossOver Office

CrossOver Office has a small set of applications that can be emulated on Linux. The list of applications supported includes Microsoft Office, Lotus Notes, Microsoft Visio, etc. Its latest version, CrossOver Office 2.0.1, is available at <http://www.codeweavers.com/products/office/>

NeTraverse Win4Lin 4.0

Developed by NeTraverse, Win4Lin 4.0 supports more Linux distributions than any other. All you need to do is download, and install it. It supports applications from Microsoft Office, Macromedia applications, and Adobe. It also supports the wheel mouse, larger memory allocation, and a larger swap partition for Windows.

VMware

VMware takes advantage of the Intel architecture, which allows virtual machines to be created at the hardware level, enabling you to use more than one operating system on the same PC. It establishes a virtual network connection between the operating systems, allowing them to communicate with each other as if they were physical computers, connected via the LAN. So, you can access the Linux virtual machine through Network Neighbourhood in Windows and vice versa. The biggest advantage being that it can have either Linux, or Windows as the host operating system.